

Association Rules and Apriori Algorithm: Mathematical Notes

Association Rule Mining is a popular technique to discover interesting relationships, or associations, among a large set of items in a dataset. It is widely used in market basket analysis, where the goal is to find relationships between items that customers frequently purchase together. The **Apriori Algorithm** is a classic and foundational algorithm for mining frequent itemsets and subsequently generating association rules.

Core Concepts:

- **Itemset:** A collection of one or more items.
- **Support (of an itemset X):** The proportion of transactions in the dataset that contain the itemset X .

$$\text{Support}(X) = \frac{\text{Number of transactions containing } X}{\text{Total number of transactions}}$$

- **Frequent Itemset:** An itemset whose support is greater than or equal to a predefined minimum support threshold (min_sup).
- **Association Rule:** An implication of the form $X \Rightarrow Y$, where X and Y are disjoint itemsets ($X \cap Y = \emptyset$). X is called the **antecedent** and Y is called the **consequent**.
- **Confidence (of a rule $X \Rightarrow Y$):** The probability that Y is in a transaction, given that X is in the transaction. It measures the reliability of the rule.

$$\text{Confidence}(X \Rightarrow Y) = \frac{\text{Support}(X \cup Y)}{\text{Support}(X)}$$

- **Lift (of a rule $X \Rightarrow Y$):** Measures how much more likely Y is bought when X is bought, while controlling for the popularity of Y . A lift value greater than 1 indicates a positive association, less than 1 indicates a negative association, and equal to 1 indicates independence.

$$\text{Lift}(X \Rightarrow Y) = \frac{\text{Support}(X \cup Y)}{\text{Support}(X) \cdot \text{Support}(Y)}$$

Dataset: Market Basket Transactions

Consider a small dataset of customer transactions at a grocery store. Each transaction lists the items purchased.

Transaction ID (TID)	Items Purchased
T1	{Milk, Bread, Diaper}
T2	{Milk, Diaper, Beer}
T3	{Milk, Coke, Diaper}
T4	{Bread, Milk}
T5	{Bread, Diaper, Beer}

Total number of transactions (N) = 5.

Goal: Discover interesting association rules from this dataset using the Apriori Algorithm.

Thresholds: Let's set the minimum support threshold: $\text{min_sup} = 60\%$ (or 0.6) This means an itemset must appear in at least $0.6 \times 5 = 3$ transactions to be considered frequent.

Let's set the minimum confidence threshold: $\text{min_conf} = 70\%$ (or 0.7)

The Apriori Algorithm: Step-by-Step Calculation

The Apriori algorithm works in a two-step process (join and prune) iteratively to find all frequent itemsets.

Phase 1: Finding all Frequent Itemsets

Iteration 1: Find Frequent 1-Itemsets (L_1)

1. **Candidate 1-Itemsets (C_1):** Count the occurrences of each individual item.

Itemset	Count
{Milk}	4
{Bread}	3
{Diaper}	4
{Beer}	2
{Coke}	1

2. **Frequent 1-Itemsets (L_1):** Prune C_1 by keeping only those itemsets whose support is $\geq \text{min_sup} = 3$.

Itemset	Count	Support
{Milk}	4	$4/5 = 0.8$
{Bread}	3	$3/5 = 0.6$
{Diaper}	4	$4/5 = 0.8$

Items {Beer} and {Coke} are discarded as their counts (2 and 1 respectively) are less than 3.

Iteration 2: Find Frequent 2-Itemsets (L_2)

1. **Candidate 2-Itemsets (C_2):** Generate candidate 2-itemsets by joining L_1 with itself. The items must be ordered lexicographically. Possible combinations from $L_1 = \{\text{Milk, Bread, Diaper}\}$:

- {Milk, Bread}
- {Milk, Diaper}
- {Bread, Diaper}

Itemset	Transactions containing
{Milk, Bread}	T1, T4
{Milk, Diaper}	T1, T2, T3
{Bread, Diaper}	T1, T5

2. **Frequent 2-Itemsets (L_2):** Count support for each candidate in C_2 and prune those below $\text{min_sup} = 3$.

Itemset	Count	Support
{Milk, Bread}	2	$2/5 = 0.4$
{Milk, Diaper}	3	$3/5 = 0.6$
{Bread, Diaper}	2	$2/5 = 0.4$

Only {Milk, Diaper} remains as its count is 3. So, $L_2 = \{\{\text{Milk, Diaper}\}\}$.

Iteration 3: Find Frequent 3-Itemsets (L_3)

1. **Candidate 3-Itemsets (C_3):** Generate candidate 3-itemsets by joining L_2 with itself (if possible) or following the Apriori principle. Since L_2 only contains one itemset ({Milk, Diaper}), we cannot form any 3-itemsets by joining two different frequent 2-itemsets. This step effectively results in an empty C_3 . The Apriori principle states: "If an itemset is frequent, then all of its subsets must also be frequent." Conversely, "If any subset of a candidate itemset is not frequent, then the candidate itemset cannot be frequent either, and can be pruned." Since we cannot form any candidate 3-itemsets whose all 2-subsets are in L_2 , C_3 is empty. Thus, L_3 is empty. The algorithm terminates.

All Frequent Itemsets Found:

- L_1 : {Milk}, {Bread}, {Diaper}
- L_2 : {Milk, Diaper}

Phase 2: Generating Association Rules from Frequent Itemsets

Now, we generate high-confidence rules from the frequent itemsets. For each frequent itemset F , all non-empty subsets of F are considered as antecedents.

Consider the only frequent 2-itemset: {Milk, Diaper}. Possible rules are:

1. $\{\text{Milk}\} \Rightarrow \{\text{Diaper}\}$

- $\text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}, \text{Diaper}\}) = 0.6$
- $\text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}\}) = 0.8$
- $\text{Confidence}(\{\text{Milk}\} \Rightarrow \{\text{Diaper}\}) = \frac{\text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}, \text{Diaper}\})}{\text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}\})} = \frac{0.6}{0.8} = 0.75$
- Since $0.75 \geq \text{min_conf} = 0.7$, this is a strong rule.
- $\text{Lift}(\{\text{Milk}\} \Rightarrow \{\text{Diaper}\}) = \frac{\text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}, \text{Diaper}\})}{\text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}\}) \cdot \text{Support}(\{\text{Diaper}\})} = \frac{0.6}{0.8 \cdot 0.8} = \frac{0.6}{0.64} \approx 0.9375$
- Interpretation of Lift: Since $\text{Lift} \approx 0.9375 < 1$, it indicates a slight negative association. Customers who buy Milk are slightly less likely to buy Diaper than expected by chance, or perhaps they are independent. This might seem counter-intuitive given the high confidence, but it suggests that Milk and Diaper are very popular individually, and while they co-occur often (leading to high confidence), their co-occurrence isn't as high as if they were truly positively associated given their individual popularity.

2. $\{\text{Diaper}\} \Rightarrow \{\text{Milk}\}$

- $\text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}, \text{Diaper}\}) = 0.6$
- $\text{Support}(\{\text{Diaper}\}) = 0.8$
- $\text{Confidence}(\{\text{Diaper}\} \Rightarrow \{\text{Milk}\}) = \frac{\text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}, \text{Diaper}\})}{\text{Support}(\{\text{Diaper}\})} = \frac{0.6}{0.8} = 0.75$
- Since $0.75 \geq \text{min_conf} = 0.7$, this is also a strong rule.
- $\text{Lift}(\{\text{Diaper}\} \Rightarrow \{\text{Milk}\}) = \frac{\text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}, \text{Diaper}\})}{\text{Support}(\{\text{Diaper}\}) \cdot \text{Support}(\{\text{Milk}\})} = \frac{0.6}{0.8 \cdot 0.8} = \frac{0.6}{0.64} \approx 0.9375$
- Interpretation of Lift: Same as above.

In this particular small dataset and with these thresholds, the only association rules found are $\{\text{Milk}\} \Rightarrow \{\text{Diaper}\}$ and $\{\text{Diaper}\} \Rightarrow \{\text{Milk}\}$, both with high confidence but slightly negative lift. This small example demonstrates the process, and in larger datasets, many more interesting rules with varying lift values would emerge.

Discussion:

- **Scalability Challenges:** Discuss the computational complexity of Apriori. Generating candidate sets can be very expensive, especially with a large number of items (2^N possible itemsets). The frequent itemset generation (Phase 1) is often the bottleneck.
- **Apriori Property (Anti-Monotonicity of Support):** Reiterate why the Apriori principle is fundamental: "If an itemset is frequent, then all of its subsets must also be frequent." This property allows for efficient pruning of candidate itemsets and is what makes Apriori feasible.
- **Alternatives to Apriori:** Introduce more advanced algorithms that address Apriori's limitations, such as:
 - **FP-Growth (Frequent Pattern Growth):** An alternative that avoids explicit candidate generation by building a compact data structure called an FP-tree. It's generally faster than Apriori, especially for dense datasets.
 - **Eclat:** Another depth-first search algorithm that uses vertical data format (TID-list for each item). Efficient for sparse datasets.
- **Interestingness Measures:** Beyond Support, Confidence, and Lift, discuss other measures to evaluate the "interestingness" of rules, such as:
 - **Conviction:** Measures how far the rule is from independence.
 - **Leverage:** Measures the difference between the probability of X and Y appearing together and what would be expected if they were independent.

Explain that a rule can have high confidence but low lift (as seen in our example), indicating it's not truly "interesting" because the consequent is just very popular anyway. Lift is crucial for finding truly associated patterns.

- **Applications beyond Market Basket Analysis:** Discuss real-world applications in diverse fields:
 - **Bioinformatics:** Finding associations between genes or protein sequences.
 - **Web Usage Mining:** Discovering navigation patterns on websites.
 - **Medical Diagnosis:** Identifying symptom-disease relationships.
 - **Fraud Detection:** Finding unusual patterns of transactions.
- **Handling Continuous Data:** Briefly touch upon how association rule mining is adapted for continuous attributes (e.g., discretization).
- **Rule Redundancy and Pruning:** Discuss how to handle redundant rules or how to prune rules that are less informative.

Prepared By:

Md. Atikuzzaman

Lecturer

Department of Computer Science and Engineering

Green University of Bangladesh

Email: atik@cse.green.edu.bd